

Guide 3 — How Images Shape Public Understanding of Crime

A guide for everyone *By Tara Abrahams and Scott Jacques · Supported by*
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Why this guide exists

Most of what people know about crime comes from images: a clip on a news site, a still from a body camera, a video on social media, a mugshot, a dashcam reel. These pictures shape what we believe about how much crime there is, who commits it, who is harmed, and what works to stop it. They also shape how juries think, how policy is made, and how communities trust—or distrust—their police.

This short guide is meant to help any reader become a more careful viewer of crime images.

1. Crime images are arguments, not mirrors

Researchers who study crime news have shown for decades that the visual coverage of crime is selective. Stories that lead with violent or unusual cases dominate, even when they are statistically rare. National U.S. studies such as [Bjornstrom and colleagues \(2010\)](https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC2904566/) (<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC2904566/>) found systematic over- and under-representation of certain racial and ethnic groups as both perpetrators and victims of crime on television news.

A useful frame from the visual-communication scholar [Kathryn Higgins \(2022\)](https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/14703572221102547) (<https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/14703572221102547>) is that crime news images offer at least five different "ways of looking" at the same event—each shaping how viewers connect to it spatially, historically, and politically.

What this means for you as a viewer: - Treat any single crime image as one frame in a much larger picture. - Ask what is *not* shown: the time before the camera arrived, the people just out of frame, the routine cases that never get filmed.

2. Body-worn camera videos are not neutral

Body-worn cameras (BWCs) were widely adopted with the promise of providing an objective record of police-public interactions. The research on what BWC video actually *does* to viewers is more cautious:

- **The same video produces different judgments depending on who is watching.** [Cross and colleagues \(2025\) \(https://doi.apa.org/doi/10.1037/lhb0000642\)](https://doi.apa.org/doi/10.1037/lhb0000642) found viewer race and political ideology meaningfully shape whether identical BWC footage is judged as procedurally just or unjust.
- **Words around the video change what people think they saw.** [Park, Feigenson and Cheng \(2024\) \(https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1002/acp.70007\)](https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1002/acp.70007) showed that brief framing—either by the prosecution or the defense—led mock jurors to agree with statements about the video that were factually false.
- **First-person camera angle is a perspective**, not a god's-eye view. It privileges what the officer saw and felt and tends to obscure the perspective of the other person in the encounter.

What this means for you as a viewer: - Watch the full clip an agency releases, not only the dramatic seconds on social media. - Watch it more than once. Try watching once with the sound off. - Be honest with yourself about your prior beliefs. They shape what you see.

3. Citizen and bystander video

Bystander video has driven some of the most consequential criminal justice stories of the past decade. The right of ordinary people to record police in public is recognized in most U.S. federal circuits ([Justia summary \(https://www.justia.com/criminal/procedure/right-to-record-police-officers/\)](https://www.justia.com/criminal/procedure/right-to-record-police-officers/)), though the [Columbia Human Rights Law Review \(2025\)](#)

https://hrlr.law.columbia.edu/files/2025/09/Rose_Codifying-the-Right-to-Record-Police_55.3.pdf) describes the right as "unsettled and under threat" in some places.

When you encounter bystander video: - Look for the original uploader, the date, the location, and a longer version. A clipped re-upload may strip critical context. - Be cautious about videos that arrive with a strong caption telling you what to feel before you've watched them. - A video can be authentic *and* misleading if it shows only part of an encounter.

4. AI and synthetic images

The line between real photographs and computer-generated ones is no longer reliably visible. The [FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center \(https://www.secureworld.io/industry-news/ai-enabled-fraud-topped-893m-fbi\)](https://www.secureworld.io/industry-news/ai-enabled-fraud-topped-893m-fbi) reported \$893 million in AI-enabled fraud losses in 2025 alone, a substantial portion driven by synthetic images, video, and voices. Generative AI is already producing crime-scene "photos," fake suspects, and fabricated police body camera "footage" that circulates as if real.

Practical habits: - Be slowest to share the most emotionally activating images. Outrage is the main delivery mechanism for synthetic content. - Look for the image on more than one outlet, ideally with a credit and date. - Watch for hands, text, jewelry, and reflections—still common giveaways in AI imagery, though they are getting better. - Use reverse-image search ([Google Images \(https://images.google.com/\)](https://images.google.com/), [TinEye \(https://tinEye.com/\)](https://tinEye.com/), [Yandex \(https://yandex.com/images/\)](https://yandex.com/images/)) before reposting. - Trust labeled corrections from outlets that publish them. As the Society of Professional Journalists [reminded its members in 2025 \(https://thespjnews.org/2025/10/17/truth-and-empathy-guide-photojournalism-ethics/\)](https://thespjnews.org/2025/10/17/truth-and-empathy-guide-photojournalism-ethics/), the right response to a synthetic image slipping into print is a public correction and removal—not a quiet edit.

5. Mugshots, perp walks, and the "criminal" image

Once a face is associated with a crime in a public image, that association is hard to undo—even if the person is later acquitted, exonerated, or never charged. A growing

number of newsrooms have stopped publishing routine arrest photographs for non-violent or unresolved cases.

When you see a mugshot or perp walk: - Note that an arrest is not a conviction. - Note that police choose which images and angles get released. - Be aware that mugshot publication patterns can reinforce racial stereotypes about who "looks like" a criminal (Bjornstrom et al., 2010 (<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC2904566/>)).

6. Victims in the frame

Crime victims and their families experience images of the worst day of their lives differently from the rest of us. The [Office for Victims of Crime](https://ovc.ojp.gov/ncvrw2025/working-with-media/advocating-with-news-media) (<https://ovc.ojp.gov/ncvrw2025/working-with-media/advocating-with-news-media>) urges media to choose images of resilience and personhood over images of trauma.

As a viewer and a sharer: - Pause before reposting images of victims, especially in the first hours after an incident, when families may not yet have been notified. - Avoid sharing images that identify minors who are victims of crime. - Recognize that a photograph that "raises awareness" can also re-traumatize the family it claims to honor.

7. A short toolkit for everyday viewing

- **Where did this come from?** Original outlet, date, location.
 - **What is *not* in the frame?** Who or what is just outside?
 - **Whose perspective is the camera taking?**
 - **What does the caption tell me to feel?** Does the image, on its own, support that feeling?
 - **Could this be synthetic, edited, or staged?**
 - **Would I be comfortable being in this image?**
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Further reading

- [Reuters Institute, *Generative AI and news 2025* \(https://reutersinstitute.politics.ox.ac.uk/generative-ai-and-news-report-2025-how-people-think-about-ais-role-journalism-and-society\)](https://reutersinstitute.politics.ox.ac.uk/generative-ai-and-news-report-2025-how-people-think-about-ais-role-journalism-and-society)
- [Columbia Business School — *AI and Misinformation* \(https://business.columbia.edu/insights/magazine/ai-and-misinformation-how-combat-false-content-2025\)](https://business.columbia.edu/insights/magazine/ai-and-misinformation-how-combat-false-content-2025)
- [News Literacy Project \(https://newslit.org/\)](https://newslit.org/)
- [Office for Victims of Crime — 2025 NCVRW media guide \(https://ovc.ojp.gov/ncvrw2025/working-with-media/advocating-with-news-media\)](https://ovc.ojp.gov/ncvrw2025/working-with-media/advocating-with-news-media)
- [CrimRxiv — open-access criminology \(https://www.crimrxiv.com/\)](https://www.crimrxiv.com/)

Uncertainty flags: many of the patterns described here are robust across studies but vary by country, year, and platform. Treat the citations as starting points, not final words.